



Should relationships be at the heart of public relations? A meta-analysis of the antecedents and consequences of organization-public relationships

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ABSTRACT

Organization-public relationships (OPRs) have been central to public relations theorizing for decades. Guided by Broom et al.'s (1997) foundational three-stage model of OPRs, this study contributes to the public relations literature by conducting the first meta-analysis of the associations between each of the four dimensions of OPRs (trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality) and their most frequently studied antecedents and consequences. A total of 454 correlations from 67 empirical studies ($N = 30,223$) were included in the analysis. The results confirmed the strong correlations among OPRs and the nine most frequently studied antecedents: engagement, involvement, authenticity, transparency, interactivity, two-way communication, interpersonal communication, mediated communication, and symmetrical communication. The research also confirmed the strong connections among OPRs and six commonly researched consequences: reputation, attitudes, positive word-of-mouth communication, purchase intentions, advocacy, and information seeking. We identified the sampling method, employee-organization relationships (EORs), organization type, and country as significant moderators for certain relationships. Overall, the findings support OPRs as a mature and well-supported theory that continues integrating with other public relations theories. Findings also enrich the three-stage model of OPRs with integrated empirical evidence. Areas for future scholarship are discussed relevant to the insignificant potential moderators, such as channel and crisis topic, along with important limitations in the extant scholarship.

1. Introduction

Building and maintaining quality organization-public relationships (OPRs) has been a goal of public relations research, practice, and education at least since Ferguson's (1984) call for focusing on relationship management (Broom et al., 1997; Cheng, 2018; Huang & Zhang, 2013; Ki & Shin, 2006; Ki et al., 2019; Page & Capizzo, 2021). Relationships are central to public relations practice and uniquely contribute to organizational effectiveness (Dozier et al., 2013; Huang, 2001b; Ki et al., 2019; Public Relations Society of America (PRSA), 2012). For instance, PRSA (2012) defines public relations from a relational approach: "Public relations is a strategic communication process that builds mutually beneficial relationships between organizations and their publics" (About public relations section).

Scholars generally agree that OPRs is a multidimensional concept (Bruning & Galloway, 2003; J. Grunig & Huang, 2000; Huang, 2001a). For instance, J. Grunig and Huang (2000) defined the dimensions of OPRs as trust, control mutuality, satisfaction, commitment, and goal

attainment, and then in 2001, added "face" and "guanxi" to incorporate unique cultural elements in Asia. In contrast, Bruning and Galloway (2003) proposed five dimensions: anthropomorphism, professional benefits/expectations, personal commitment, community improvement, and comparison of alternatives.

Another equally important research line is advancing relationship theory by proposing and testing antecedents and consequences of OPRs, as evidenced by Ki et al.'s (2019) bibliometric analysis. This area has abundant scholarship but lacks meta-analysis studies to understand what factors influence the strength of these associations. Systematic reviews have summarized the status and future directions of OPRs research over the last 22 years (Cheng, 2018; Dong et al., 2023; Huang & Zhang, 2013; Ki & Shin, 2006). Recently, a meta-analysis examined the relationship between each dimension of OPRs and publics' engagement and organizational openness (Zhan & Zhao, 2023). The authors of this study suggested that more antecedents, consequences, and moderators should be examined with meta-analytic evidence to advance OPRs theorizing.

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Therefore, this study computed the effect sizes of the most common antecedents and consequences of OPRs and examined the moderators of these relationships to give a broad picture of to what extent OPRs is supported and aligned with the relational core of many public relations practices. Through a meta-analysis of 454 associations from 67 published studies ($N = 30, 223$), this study examined how dimensions of OPRs (i.e., trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality) relate to 15 commonly researched antecedents and consequences and what factors moderate these relationships.

In doing so, this study reconciles incongruous findings in the prior research and sets an agenda for future research. Specifically, through enriching Broom et al.'s (1997) three-stage model of OPRs (i.e., relationship dimensions, antecedents to relationships, and consequences of relationships) with empirical evidence, this study proposes an integrated theoretical framework for comprehensively mapping the dominant antecedents and consequences of quality OPRs (Broom et al., 2000; Huang & Zhang, 2015; Ki & Shin, 2015; Ledingham, 2003). Also, given that OPRs is a dominant framework in public relations research (Huang & Zhang, 2013; Ki & Shin, 2015; Page & Capizzo, 2021), understanding to what extent the framework holds up across studies offers directions for future developments to OPRs and other public relations theories investigating relationships.

2. Literature review

This section reviews the research on Broom et al.'s (1997) three-stage model of OPRs (antecedents, dimensions of OPRs, and consequences) and potential moderators of OPRs. We focus on the research gaps in the existing literature that our meta-analysis addresses.

2.1. The three-stage model of OPRs

Informed by systems theory, Broom et al. (1997) proposed a three-stage framework to develop theoretical propositions about the formation and impact of OPRs (Cutlip et al., 1994; Huang & Zhang, 2015; Ki & Shin, 2015; Ledingham, 2003). Specifically, antecedents to relationships refer to the various precursors that influence the formation of relationships. These precursors could include perceptions, motivations, needs, and behaviors, among others, which are postulated as contingencies or as causes in the formation of relationships (Broom et al., 1997; Cutlip et al., 1994). Consequences of relationships are the outcomes that “have the effects of changing the environment and of achieving, maintaining, or changing goal states both inside and outside the organization” (Broom et al., 1997, p. 94). This framework illustrates OPRs as outcomes of, as well as causes for, other changes. For instance, organizations employing transparent communication may improve OPRs. Conversely, publics' attitudes towards an organization may change as one of the consequences of OPRs changing. In other words, OPRs work as both dependent and independent variables, as well as intervening variables in the three-stage model (Broom et al., 1997; Huang & Zhang, 2015; Ki & Shin, 2015; Ledingham, 2003).

Although there are other models available, such as J. Grunig and Huang's (2000) three-step model (OPRs precursor, maintenance strategies, and outcomes) and Ledingham's (2001) expansion of the five-step process model (scan, map, roll-out, track, and steward), we adopt the structure of the three-stage model because it fits best with the purpose of the study. Our goal is to select the most commonly used variables that also meet the requirements of a meta-analysis to comprehensively map the dominant antecedents and consequences of quality OPRs. In the following subsections, the three-stage model serves as the foundation for a review of the dimensions of OPRs, their antecedents, and consequences. In these subsections, a comprehensive review of all the included variables is presented to further understanding of these variables' roles and significance in shaping and reflecting the dynamics of OPRs. The results of our meta-analysis enrich the three-stage model of OPRs by building integrated empirical support and

provide a clear direction for future theorizing.

2.2. Dimensions of OPRs

Two clusters of studies on dimensions of OPRs have appeared in the literature (Huang & Zhang, 2013). One cluster originated from the relationship measurement scale developed by Hon and Grunig (1999) and Huang's (2001a) organization-public relationship assessment (OPRA). Subsequently, scholars, including Ki and Hon (2007a) and Shen (2017), sought to refine these measures. This body of scholarship included four dimensions: trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality. Among these dimensions, trust is the confidence and willingness of both organizations and publics to open up to one another and includes three underlying dimensions: integrity, dependability, and competence (Hon & Grunig, 1999; Ki & Hon, 2007a; Shen, 2017). Satisfaction refers to how each party in a relationship shows favorable feelings toward the other. Commitment represents how each party believes maintaining and promoting the relationship is worthwhile for their time and effort (Hon & Grunig, 1999; Huang, 2001a; Shen, 2017). Last, control mutuality is a dimension that highlights how power could be changed by influencing communication and eventual decisions, defined as “how much each party of the relationship agrees on his or her rightful power to influence each other” (Hon & Grunig, 1999, p. 3; Ki & Hon, 2007a).

Bruning and colleagues represent another cluster of studies that defined OPRs from the perspective of publics' attitudes toward an organization. This work measured OPRs as anthropomorphism, professional benefits/expectations, personal commitment, community improvement, and comparison of alternatives (e.g., Bruning & Galloway, 2003; Ledingham, 2001, 2015; Ledingham & Bruning, 1998).

This study applies the dimensions developed by the first research cluster for three reasons. First, Hon and Grunig's (1999) four dimensions have been considered essential facets of relationship quality (Ki et al., 2019; Ki & Hon, 2007a; Kim & Rhee, 2011). Second, Ki and Hon (2007a) argued that Hon and J. Grunig's dimensions are more reasonable and justifiable for evaluating relationship outcomes compared to other scales. Last, Hon and J. Grunig's dimensions represent the most often applied OPRs scale, as shown by later searches in the literature to identify qualifying studies for this meta-analysis. The next section discusses the antecedents of OPRs.

2.3. Antecedents of OPRs

In the three-stage model of OPRs, OPRs have been regarded as dependent variables, and scholars have tested the influences of different response and maintenance strategies, message features, and publics' perceptual variables on OPRs (e.g., Cheng, 2018; Dong et al., 2023; Huang & Zhang, 2013; Morehouse & Saffer, 2020; Zhan & Zhao, 2023). We further discuss engagement and involvement below as one antecedent of quality OPRs.

2.3.1. Engagement and Involvement

Public relations scholars have conceptualized and operationalized engagement and involvement in various contexts (e.g., Chen, 2017; Johnston & Taylor, 2018; Kang, 2014; Men & Tsai, 2013; Morehouse & Saffer, 2020). See Fig. 1 for commonly applied definitions of different types of engagement and involvement. This study adopts Johnston and Taylor's (2018) integrated definition of engagement, which is “a dynamic multidimensional relational concept featuring psychological and behavioral attributes of connection, interaction, participation, and involvement, designed to achieve or elicit an outcome at individual, organization, or social levels” (p. 19).

Research generally finds that engagement and involvement have significant positive impacts on OPRs across topics and countries (e.g., Browning et al., 2020; Cheng, 2018; Harrison, 2018; Kang & Park, 2017; Men & Tsai, 2013, 2014, 2015, 2016; Tsai & Men, 2018), except for

Indicative publications	Concepts	Example definitions
Kujala et al. (2022)	Stakeholder engagement	“[...] various processes and strategies that firms and other organizations implement in their stakeholder relations” (p. 1140).
Taylor and Kent (2014)	Dialogic engagement	“[...] both an orientation that influences interactions and the approach that guides the process of interactions among groups” (p. 384).
Ferreira et al. (2020)	Consumer engagement	“[...] a consumer’s positive cognitive, emotional and behavioral investment in a focal object through direct (Hollebeek, 2011a) or indirect interactions, such as with websites, brand communities or advertising” (p. 492).
Men and Tsai (2014)	Public engagement	“[...] a behavioral construct with hierarchical activity levels, from passive message consumption to active two-way conversation, participation, and online recommendation” (p. 419).
Kang (2014)	Public engagement	“[...] a psychologically motivated affective state that brings voluntary extra-role behaviors, and is characterized by affective commitment, positive affectivity and empowerment that an individual public experiences in interactions with an organization over time” (p. 402).
Heath (2018)	Engagement	“[...] the ultimate relational decision-making tension between individuals of all types and levels of generality” (p. 33).
Johnston and Taylor (2018)	Engagement	“[...] a dynamic multidimensional relational concept featuring psychological and behavioral attributes of connection, interaction, participation, and involvement, designed to achieve or elicit an outcome at individual, organization, or social levels” (p. 19).
Zaichkowsky (1985)	Involvement	“[...] a person’s perceived relevance of the object based on inherent needs, values, and interests” (p. 342).
Kim and Grunig (2011)	Involvement	“[...] the actual connection of events or problems is important as a trigger of perception” (p.129).
Harrison (2018)	Involvement	“[...] the level of an individual’s feelings of investment in a product, while being sensitive to personal, physical, and situational differences” (p.537).

Fig. 1. Exemplary Definitions for Engagement and Involvement, Kujala et al. (2022); Taylor and Kent (2014); Ferreira et al. (2020); Men and Tsai (2014); Kang (2014); Heath (2018); Johnston and Taylor (2018); Zaichkowsky (1985); Kim and Grunig (2011); Harrison (2018).

Sission’s study (2017), which only found a significant relationship between control mutuality and engagement. However, the differences between the strengths of the relationships found so far are large. For example, Chen (2017), Men and Muralidharan (2017), and Tsai and Men (2018) found larger effect sizes of engagement on trust, ranging from 0.63 to 0.83, compared to Bortree (2011) and Harrison (2018), only ranging from 0.38 to 0.47. Similar small effect sizes of engagement also appeared on satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality (e.g., Dong & Ji, 2018; Kujur & Singh, 2019; Men & Tsai, 2016). There might be some underlying factors causing these differences. One possible factor is the channel organizations employ to cultivate OPRs with key publics. For instance, research finds that social media offer more engagement features than websites (Men & Tsai, 2016; Tsai & Men, 2018). Zhan and Zhao (2023) found that organization type (for-profit organizations vs. others), samples collected from different cultures (Eastern vs. Western), and different types of populations may be moderators. Our study aims to examine more potential moderators in these associations.

Notably, some studies with a small effect size use the operationalization of involvement. Some scholars believe that engagement and involvement are interchangeable, suggesting “the broadly defined engagement is often used interchangeably with such terms as

‘involvement’ and ‘dialogue’” (Lewis et al., 2001 as cited in Men & Tsai, 2015, p. 396). However, involvement has its own definition and scale in much involvement-related research (e.g., Bortree, 2011; Browning et al., 2020; Harrison, 2018). For example, Harrison et al. (2017), Harrison (2018), and Browning et al. (2020) applied the definition and scale of Zaichkowsky (1985), taking it as “a person’s perceived relevance of the object based on inherent needs, values, and interests” (Zaichkowsky, 1985, p. 342). In this study, we regard engagement and involvement as two distinct concepts and investigate whether they have similar effect sizes on OPRs to resolve this dispute. The following section introduces OPRs maintenance strategies.

2.3.2. Maintenance strategies

Four common relational maintenance or cultivation strategies are defined as “any organizational behavioral efforts that attempt to establish, cultivate, and sustain relationships with strategic publics” (Ki & Hon, 2009, p. 5). These maintenance strategies have been identified as the ways organizations maintain and cultivate quality OPRs, specifically by encouraging ethical and two-way interactions to achieve mutual understanding and benefits for both organizations and publics (Dozier & Broom, 1995; L. Grunig et al., 2002; Huang, 2001b; Lee & Kim, 2020, 2021; Ni et al., 2015; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b; Shen & Kim, 2012;

Wang et al., 2014).

Specifically, two-way communication describes the degree to which organizations engage in dialogue with publics, attempting to understand their thoughts and opinions (L. Grunig et al., 2002; Ni et al., 2015; Wang et al., 2014). Symmetrical communication emphasizes the balance of interests and outcomes between an organization and its publics (Dozier & Broom, 1995; L. Grunig et al., 2002; Men & Jiang, 2016; Men & Sung, 2022). In terms of communication modes, these modes can range from mediated communication to interpersonal communication (L. Grunig et al., 2002; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b). Interpersonal communication pertains to public relations activities that take place face-to-face, while mediated communication involves public relations activities that are conducted through mass media or mediated materials (L. Grunig et al., 2002; Ni et al., 2015; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b).

Almost all studies have found that these maintenance strategies positively affect OPRs overall, but findings have differed regarding the specific dimensions (Huang, 2001b; Kim, 2018; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee et al., 2022). For instance, Huang (2001b) found that two-way communication only significantly affects commitment, while Ni et al. (2015) and Kim (2018) found that two-way communication also significantly affects other dimensions. In contrast, Kim and Rhee (2011) found that symmetrical communication significantly influences satisfaction and commitment but not trust and control mutuality. This study integrates existing research on the effects of these maintenance strategies on OPRs and helps to answer the underlying reasons for the inconsistent findings. The next section reviews research on interactivity, another antecedent of quality OPRs.

2.3.3. Interactivity

Interactivity refers to the affordance of interactive communication among organizations and publics facilitated by the Internet and social media (Jo & Kim, 2003; Vafeiadis, 2021). As one of the most important Internet and social media characteristics, interactivity has received widespread attention, and scholars often found that the interactivity provided on social media, such as replies and mentions, assists organizations in building relationships with publics (e.g., Chen, 2017; Saffer et al., 2013; Tong, 2021). Interactivity is often tested as a grouping factor in experimental studies, and its effect sizes have varied from minimal to large, ranging from 0.05 to 0.78 (Jo & Kim, 2003; Li & Li, 2014; Vafeiadis, 2021). Such large differences in effect sizes across studies warrant moderation analysis for our meta-analysis. The next section introduces authenticity as another antecedent of quality OPRs addressed in our meta-analysis.

2.3.4. Authenticity

Authenticity refers to organizations that do not manipulate their publics (Henderson & Brookhart, 1996). This concept was first introduced as a mediator between symmetrical communication and OPRs by Shen and Kim (2012). Subsequent research found that authenticity has strong correlations with OPRs across a variety of topics, including the authenticity of a government organization (Men et al., 2018), a CEO (Men, 2021; Men & Tsai, 2016), and employees' perceptions of for-profit organizations (Kelleher et al., 2019; Men, 2015; Men & Jiang, 2016; Thelen, 2021). However, no research has clearly articulated why the strength of the effects of authenticity on OPRs varies across these different topics and organization types. This study seeks to answer this question.

2.3.5. Transparency

The concept of organizational transparency has attracted significant interest from both the academic and professional fields in recent years, particularly in internal communication research (Kelleher et al., 2019; Kim & Lee, 2021; Lee et al., 2021; Li et al., 2021; Men, 2015; Men & Stacks, 2014; Rawlins, 2009; Yue et al., 2019). While this concept shares close theoretical ties with authenticity, transparency is characterized by its emphasis on openness and visibility, compared to authenticity's

grounding in truthfulness and consistency (Men & Tsai, 2014). Transparency involves three aspects: informational, participation, and accountability. Rawlins (2009) defined transparency as "the deliberate attempt to make available all legally releasable information—whether positive or negative in nature—in a manner that is accurate, timely, balanced, and unequivocal, for the purpose of enhancing the reasoning ability of publics and holding organizations accountable for their actions, policies, and practices." (p. 75). Rawlins (2008, 2009) argued that to build and restore trust with stakeholders, transparency efforts of organizations need all three aspects.

Regarding the evidence, to date, the majority of research in internal communication contexts has found strong correlations between each dimension of employee-organization relationships (EORs) and transparency (e.g., Kelleher et al., 2019; Kim & Lee, 2021; Lee et al., 2021; Li et al., 2021; Men, 2015). However, the correlations between transparency and OPRs are not as strong in external contexts (Dong & Ji, 2018; Men & Tsai, 2014). This study aims to provide an overall effect size for transparency and OPRs and explore whether the research topic significantly moderates these relationships.

Based on the above literature review, we present our first research question:

RQ1. : What are the relationships among (a) engagement, (b) symmetrical communication, (c) two-way communication, (d) interpersonal communication, (e) mediated communication, (f) interactivity, (g) authenticity, (h) transparency, and (i) involvement and the four dimensions of organization-public relationships (i.e., control mutuality, trust, satisfaction, and commitment)?

We now turn to the consequences of OPRs, as guided by the three-stage model.

2.4. Consequences of OPRs

As outlined in the three-stage model of OPRs (Broom et al., 1997), a central research focus is the exploration of the consequences of OPRs. Scholars have viewed OPRs as independent variables and tested the influences of OPRs on publics' perceptions of organizations, attitudes towards organizations, and behavioral outcomes (Broom et al., 1997; Cheng, 2018; Huang & Zhang, 2015; Ki & Shin, 2015; Ledingham, 2003). For instance, Ki (2013) found that OPRs can predict publics' attitudes and behaviors toward the banking industry. Prior literature generally found mixed results regarding the effect sizes of OPRs on these consequences (e.g., Kang & Yang, 2010; Liu et al., 2017; Ma, 2018; Park & Reber, 2011). Our meta-analysis adds greater clarity to the effects of OPRs on the studied consequences. Next, we discuss OPRs research on organizational reputation.

2.4.1. Reputation

Reputation, defined as "what people think about organizations and also what organizations are in the eyes of others" (Brønn, 2010, p. 309), has long been regarded as one of the dominant consequences of OPRs (e.g., Al-salhi et al., 2021; Grunig & Hung-Baesecke, 2015; Yang, 2007). Yang (2007) was the first quantitative study to link organizational reputation with OPRs and found significant connections. Researchers have generally found that OPRs positively affect organizational reputation in various organizational contexts (e.g., Al-salhi et al., 2021; Kim et al., 2020; Seltzer et al., 2013; Sung & Yang, 2008; Yang, 2007). However, the effect sizes of relationships between OPRs and reputation in the literature are diverse, ranging from 0.38 to 0.82. This meta-analysis helps identify what underlying factors caused such differences in the strength of the effects of OPRs on organizational reputation. Next, we briefly review research on OPRs and attitudes.

2.4.2. Attitudes

Attitudes are widely defined, and OPRs have even been defined from the perspective of public's attitudes toward an organization (Bruning &

Ledingham, 1999; Huang & Zhang, 2015). However, within the scholarship that employs attitudes as a consequence of OPRs, a distinction is made between OPRs and attitudes (Browning et al., 2020; Kang & Yang, 2010; Ki & Hon, 2007b, 2012; Kim & Chan-Olmsted, 2005; Kim & Gower, 2021; Ma, 2018; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b). These studies assume that OPRs influence attitudes, given that OPRs indicate key publics either have supportive or unsupportive feelings toward an organization (Ki & Hon, 2007b, 2012). Despite the fact that attitudes have been applied to varying topics including brand attitudes (e.g., Kim & Chan-Olmsted, 2005), attitudes toward political parties (e.g., Seltzer et al., 2013; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b), and attitudes toward sports teams (e.g., Kim & Gower, 2021), we found that the definition of attitudes provided by Ki and Hon (2012) captures the conceptualization of attitudes in the body of work treating attitudes as a consequence of OPRs. Hence, in this study, attitudes refer to an “evaluation of an organization by members of a public” (Ki & Hon, 2012, p. 191) as influenced by OPRs.

Previous studies have generally found that OPRs positively affect publics’ attitudes (e.g., Kang & Yang, 2010; Kim & Gower, 2021; Ma, 2018; Seltzer et al., 2013), but Ki and Hon (2007b) found that trust is not a significant predictor of attitudes, and commitment negatively affects attitudes. The current meta-analysis seeks to uncover factors leading to these different findings by comparing the existing studies taking attitudes as one of their outcomes. We now turn to a review of another consequence of healthy OPRs: positive word-of-mouth communication.

2.4.3. Positive word-of-mouth communication

Positive word-of-mouth communication is a critical endorsement for organizations, shaping publics’ attitudes and behaviors (Browning et al., 2020; Chen et al., 2021; Lee & Youn, 2009). The digital era has amplified the impact of word-of-mouth, extending its reach from one-to-one or one-to-many, to many-to-one and many-to-many communications (Liu et al., 2017; Weisfeld-Spolter et al., 2014).

Substantial literature supports a positive correlation between OPRs and publics’ positive word-of-mouth intentions (Browning et al., 2020; Chen et al., 2021; Ki & Hon, 2007b; Liu et al., 2017; Shen & Kim, 2012). However, there is a noticeable variance in the reported effect sizes. For instance, Browning et al. (2020) reported a correlation of 0.87 between trust and positive word-of-mouth, whereas Shen and Kim (2012), Kang and Yang (2010), and Liu et al. (2017) reported effect sizes of approximately half of Browning et al.’s estimation. Thus, this study aims to derive an average effect size, reconciling these divergent results. Additionally, this study identifies possible moderators that could explain this discrepancy, enhancing our understanding of the dynamics between OPRs and positive word-of-mouth communication.

2.4.4. Purchase intentions

As one of the most widely applied outcomes in public relations research, previous studies have generally found positive effects of OPRs on publics’ purchase intentions, with effect sizes ranging from 0.22 to 0.67 (e.g., Abitbol & Sternadori, 2019; Browning et al., 2020; Dhanesh & Duthler, 2019; Kim & Gower, 2021; Liu et al., 2017; Ma, 2018). The current study synthesizes all available OPRs studies taking purchase intentions as an outcome to establish the average effects of OPRs on purchase intentions across all samples. Now, we turn to another outcome of positive OPRs: advocacy.

2.4.5. Advocacy

Advocacy has been mainly studied in employee-organization relationships (EOR) research and defined as a type of behavior in which publics are “actively and voluntarily promoting a company through positive word of mouth or defending against critics for the company, its products, or its brands” (Tsai & Men, 2017, p.7). Sweeney et al. (2020) argued that this concept is a distinctive form of positive word-of-mouth communication because it “entails a strongly expressed recommendation, delivered in a forceful manner, which reflects a more entrenched

relationship, such that advocates even defend the organization against rivals” (p. 139).

Existing literature has found that EORs’ influence on employee advocacy is positive and strong (Kim & Lee, 2021; Lee & Kim, 2021; Men, 2014; Thelen, 2021). However, effect sizes vary. For example, the effect sizes of control mutuality on advocacy ranged from 0.32 to 0.70 across studies (Kim & Lee, 2021; Men & Tsai, 2014; Thelen, 2021). The current study aims to find moderators leading to these differences. Next, we review the last studied consequence of OPRs: information seeking.

2.4.6. Information seeking

Information seeking is the “planned scanning of the environment for messages about a specified topic” (J. Grunig, 1997, p. 9; Kim & Grunig, 2011). Positive OPRs indicate that publics are connected to an organization. Further, the organization is a trustworthy source that publics can turn to when they need information on a topic that is relevant to the organization (Ni et al., 2019). From the situational theory of problem solving (STOPS) perspective, relational trust increases involvement recognition, which in turn increases information seeking (Ni et al., 2019). Previous findings regarding the impacts of OPRs on information seeking have been mixed. For example, some studies have found that trust positively impacts publics’ information seeking (Cheng & Shen, 2022; Cheng & Cameron, 2019; Lee, 2020), but other studies have insignificant findings (Liu & Ni, 2021; Ni et al., 2019). Similarly, regarding the impact of control mutuality on information seeking, the results of existing studies are mixed (Liu & Ni, 2021; Ni et al., 2019; Lee, 2020). The current study helps address these differences by exploring several potential moderators from existing studies.

Based on the above literature review, we present the second research question:

RQ2. : What are the relationships between the four dimensions of organization-public relationships (i.e., control mutuality, trust, satisfaction, and commitment) and (a) organizational reputation, (b) publics’ attitudes, (c) publics’ purchase intentions, (d) publics’ positive word-of-mouth communication, (e) publics’ advocacy, and (f) publics’ information seeking?

The final section of the literature review discusses research on moderators of OPRs.

2.5. Moderators in prior research

As the three-stage model of OPRs (Broom et al., 1997) did not identify moderators in these three stages, this study enriches the three-stage model by testing possible moderators that shape the strength of relationships among OPRs, antecedents, and consequences, suggested by prior literature (Broom et al., 1997; Cheng et al., 2022; Chon & Park, 2021; Huang, 2001a; Kim et al., 2020; Lee & Kim, 2020; Liu & Huang, 2021; Ma, 2019; Men, 2014; Seltzer et al., 2013; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b). One potential moderator is the country where the research has been conducted. For instance, the effects of symmetrical communication on OPRs were different in China (Huang, 2001a) and the U.S. (Lee & Kim, 2020; Men, 2014), perhaps due to cultural differences. Culture is perceived as the force defining the basic values and norms of society members and may moderate publics’ ways of interacting with organizations (Lee & Jun, 2013; Men & Jiang, 2016; Yong et al., 2012). Other potential moderators come from the public relations meta-analysis literature, which includes the sample type (i.e., whether using a student or nonstudent sample) and the sampling method (i.e., whether using a representative or unrepresentative sample) (e.g., Ma & Zhan, 2016; Wang et al., 2021).

The employee-organization relationships (EORs) topic, crisis topic, communication channel, and organization type also show the potential to be significant moderators for the examined relationships from a theoretical perspective. Employees are a primary public for organizations (Ulmer, 2001). OPRs may function differently for employees

compared to external publics, such as consumers and voters, due to employees' possibly deeper connections with organizations stemming from their employment. For example, internal publics have responded differently to an organization's misdeed than external publics because of internal publics' organizational identity (Ma, 2019). Employees may protect or defend an organization when external publics criticize it (Caillouet & Allen, 1996).

When organizations experience crises, OPRs may function differently on outcomes than during non-crisis times because during crises organizations and publics are under pressure (Cheng et al., 2022; Chon & Park, 2021). Previous studies have demonstrated that the strength and impacts of OPRs on crisis outcomes, such as organizational reputation and publics' communicative behaviors, can be challenged if publics' crisis information needs are not adequately fulfilled (Chon & Park, 2021; Kim et al., 2019; Liu & Huang, 2021). Given the dominance of crisis communication in the public relations literature (Page & Capizzo, 2021), the possible moderating effect of the crisis topic on OPRs warrants examination.

The channels organizations use to cultivate OPRs may also be a significant moderator. Utz et al. (2013) argued that the choice of medium affects publics' sense-making. They found that publics who receive crisis information via social media have fewer negative reactions to organizations compared to those who receive information via traditional media. The interactive nature of social media indicates that these channels are conducive to timely two-way communication as well as other affordances (Zhou & Xu, 2021). Consequently, an organization's choice of medium may affect OPRs.

Lastly, organization types may be an important moderator because different types of organizations may connect with their publics differently. For instance, many nonprofits are dependent on public donations and volunteering to operate. As a result, nonprofits are "held to higher expectations than most for-profit entities" (Sisco, 2012, p. 4). As another example, governmental organizations need publics' support in making and implementing policies that affect people's lives (Seltzer et al., 2013; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b). Such diverse connections to publics may affect how OPRs function in different types of organizations.

Therefore, we put forward our third and fourth research questions to explore potential moderators:

RQ3. : What variables, if any, moderate the relationships between the antecedents and the four organization-public relationships dimensions?

RQ4. : What variables, if any, moderate the relationship between the four organization-public relationships dimensions and the consequences?

3. Method

We employed a meta-analysis approach with a two-step keyword search in various electronic databases to identify pertinent studies that quantitatively examined the selected antecedents or consequences of OPRs. We specifically focused on studies published from 1999 to the end of January 2022. The final sample size for this meta-analysis is 67 articles with 454 correlations in total ($N = 30, 223$). Following the data collection, we utilized the Comprehensive Meta-Analysis Software (CMA) program 3.0 version to conduct the analysis using the random effects model. In cases of dependent effect sizes, we applied a robust variance estimation technique. The study's approach is detailed further below.

3.1. Data collection

Following the meta-analysis literature (Eisend, 2017; Xu, 2020), a two-step keyword search of electronic databases was taken to identify pertinent studies directly testing the antecedents and outcomes of OPRs. Articles with any of the following terms, either in titles, abstracts, and/or keywords, were checked for analysis: "organization-public

relationship(s)," "OPR," "relationship management," or "relationship building." The results of this keyword strategy are likely to be reliable. Even though missing studies may still exist, they are more likely to be missing at random instead of systematically (Eisend, 2017; Xu, 2020).

First, we checked for original research from 1999, the year Hon and J. Grunig's relationship measurement scale was published, to the end of January 2022 in leading databases, including Communication and Mass Media Complete, PsycInfo, Psychology and Behavioral Sciences Collection, Academic Search Ultimate, Google Scholar, and Web of Science. One hundred seventy-three articles were identified in these databases. Later, 14 articles were excluded for not using trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality as dimensions of OPRs. Twenty-three articles were excluded because they were qualitative/theoretical/review articles. We then recorded what antecedent and outcome variables were examined in the remaining 136 studies. A total of 74 antecedents and 35 outcomes were identified in the remaining studies.

Kirca et al. (2005) argued that a meta-analysis could be conducted with at least three effect sizes for a single association. Later, Eisend (2017) demonstrated that at least four effect sizes for a single association are needed for conducting a meta-analysis. Through a detailed review of the remaining studies, we found that only ten antecedents (i.e., engagement, symmetrical communication, two-way communication, interpersonal communication, mediated communication, interactivity, authenticity, involvement, transparency/transparent communication, and social media dependency) and seven outcomes (i.e., reputation, attitudes, purchase intentions, positive word-of-mouth communication, advocacy, information seeking, and problem recognition) were examined four or more times for all four dimensions and, thus, could be considered in the analysis. Therefore, 43 articles were excluded because they did not examine these antecedents and outcomes.

Of the rest of the remaining 96 articles, 29 had enough statistics for computing effect size, and 67 did not. To include the largest possible number of studies in the meta-analysis, we reached out to all authors who did not report the necessary statistics for a meta-analysis and requested these statistics. We first contacted the 40 corresponding authors for 67 articles' statistics via email in early February 2022. Then at the end of February 2022, we sent reminder emails to 20 authors who had not responded. Finally, in the middle of March 2022, we sent eight final follow-up emails. Following previous meta-analysis practices (e.g., Ismagilova et al., 2020; Ou & Ho, 2022; Wang et al., 2021) and based on the authors' responses, we only included nine antecedents and six outcomes of OPRs in the current study, excluding social media dependency and problem recognition for lacking enough statistics. The final sample size for this meta-analysis is 67 articles with 454 correlations in total ($N = 30, 223$).

3.2. Inclusion criteria

There are two criteria for studies to be included in this study. First, the study must have quantitatively examined the selected antecedents or consequences of OPRs. Second, only studies that hypothesized specific associations and directions are included. Thus, studies that did not link these variables or hypothesize associations with contrast directions were not included because they do not align with what the current study's aim to synthesize, in line with prior research (Ismagilova et al., 2020). For example, Kang and Sung (2017) hypothesized engagement as a consequence of OPRs instead of its antecedent. Therefore, this study was not included.

3.3. Unit of analysis

The zero-order correlation r was calculated and used as the effect size measure for each investigation. If an article conducted multiple studies using different samples, each study's results were treated as providing a separate effect size estimate (Ou & Ho, 2022; Wang et al., 2016, 2021).

3.4. Coding procedures

A coding scheme was completed after the literature search and multiple rounds of team discussions. All articles were coded according to the predesigned coding scheme, and coders resolved disagreements via discussion and further coding training. Apart from the basic information of these studies, coding variables also included methodological and contextual characteristics that could moderate the examined relationships. These moderators include sample type (i.e., students, nonstudent, vs. combined), sampling method (i.e., representative vs. nonrepresentative), country, measurement of positive word-of-mouth communication (either alone vs. with other items), crisis topic (crisis vs. non-crisis research), the EORs topic (i.e., employee vs. non-employee research), channel (including no mention, traditional media, websites, and social media), and organization types (including for-profit organizations, non-profit organization (NPOs), political organizations and governments, and combined). Combined organization refers to those studies that examined more than one type of organization. For example, Kelleher et al. (2019) examined how the authenticity of a leader's social media post influences employee perceptions and OPRs for all types of organizations.

For the first round of coding training, two team members coded three randomly selected articles together (5% of the total sample). The average intercoder reliability (Krippendorff's Alpha) for all variables was 0.984. After discussions, the same two researchers coded five new randomly selected articles together (7.5% of the total sample), reaching a reliability coefficient of 0.976 for the second round of coder training. Next, the same two researchers coded another two random articles together (3% of the total sample), finally reaching a reliability coefficient of 1. After these three rounds of coding training with ten articles in total (15% of the total sample), one researcher coded the remaining 57 articles.

3.5. Analysis approach

We used the Comprehensive Meta-Analysis Software (CMA) program 3.0 version to conduct the analysis based on the random effects model. The random effects model was chosen because it assumes between-study differences in effect sizes are due to the between-study differences in populations and methods instead of only the sampling error (Field & Gillert, 2010). The effect sizes from individual studies were weighted based on sample sizes. Following Hunter and Schmidt's (2004) practice, we corrected the measurement errors using the reported reliability coefficients of the independent and dependent variables.

Q statistics and I^2 on the heterogeneity of effect sizes were used to justify our moderator analysis. A statistically significant Q value indicates that the estimations' heterogeneous distributions are large and should be interpreted by additional moderation analysis. Similarly, an I^2 value exceeding 75% indicates the necessity of conducting a moderation analysis (Huedo-Medina et al., 2006; Wang et al., 2021).

When conducting a moderation analysis, Fu et al. (2011) argued that four effect sizes per subgroup for a categorical moderator are recommended in subgroup analysis. Previous meta-analyses in communication research have reported subgroup analysis results with three effect sizes in each subgroup (Ou & Ho, 2022; Wang et al., 2016; Wang et al., 2021). Therefore, we decided to exclude subgroups with less than three effect sizes in the subgroup analysis.

Additionally, several studies have dependent effect sizes for certain correlations (e.g., Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a; Yang & Grunig, 2005). For example, Yang and Grunig (2005) measured perceived OPRs of five different companies using one sample and how publics' perceptions of involvement with these companies led to different OPRs. To address this dependency, we employed robust variance estimation (RVE), an innovative technique that allows handling dependent effect sizes in a meta-analysis, with small sample size corrections using the *robumeta* in R (Pustejovsky & Tipton, 2021; Tanner-Smith et al., 2016).

4. Results

4.1. Correlation tests

4.1.1. Research question 1: antecedents of OPRs

Table 1 presents the observed and corrected mean correlations between all antecedents and each dimension of OPRs. Generally, symmetrical communication, engagement, transparency, and authenticity were the four antecedents with the most substantial relationships that were highly correlated with each dimension of OPRs. Most of the correlations for other antecedents were at a moderate to high level, which suggests that these antecedents also play essential roles in predicting publics' perceptions of OPRs. Interestingly, mediated communication almost consistently showed the weakest correlations to each dimension of OPRs among all antecedents. Another important finding is that engagement consistently has stronger effects on OPRs than involvement.

4.1.2. Research Question 2: Consequences of OPRs

Table 2 presents the observed and corrected mean correlations between each dimension of OPRs and all six consequences. Generally, attitudes, reputation, advocacy, and positive word-of-mouth communication were the four most important consequences, which correlated with each dimension at a high level. All correlations regarding other consequences were at a moderate to high level, which suggests that these outcomes play important roles in understanding what consequences OPRs can lead to. Interestingly, information seeking almost consistently showed the lowest correlations to each dimension among all consequences.

4.2. Moderator analysis

The results of the heterogeneity tests (i.e., Q and I^2 values) suggested that most of the relationships were affected by the possible moderators, as shown in Tables 1 and 2. Thus, we performed subgroup analysis to test all potential moderators to all these pairwise relationships. Due to the limited sample size, this study was unable to examine moderators for associations with fewer than six correlations, such as associations from control mutuality to advocacy, commitment and satisfaction to information seeking, and advocacy.

4.2.1. Research Question 3: moderators for antecedents to OPRs

As presented in Table 3, the country where the individual studies were conducted significantly moderated three pairwise relationships. Specifically, engagement consistently exerted a stronger influence on trust, satisfaction, and commitment in China than in the U.S., the only two countries included in the sample with adequate effect sizes to analyze. The relationship between engagement and control mutuality does not have enough effect sizes to conduct the moderation analysis. In addition, representative samples tend to produce a significantly stronger relationship between symmetrical communication and commitment than nonrepresentative samples. Moreover, the employee-organization relationships research topic significantly moderates relationships between some dimensions and authenticity and symmetrical communication. Lastly, organization types significantly moderate relationships between all OPRs dimensions and symmetrical communication, indicating that the associations between symmetrical communication and OPRs are consistently stronger for for-profit organizations than political organizations and combined (i.e., studies that did not confine organizations to specific types).

4.2.2. Research Question 4: moderators for consequences of OPRs

As presented in Table 4, representative samples tend to produce a significantly weaker relationship between commitment and reputation than nonrepresentative samples. Additionally, organization type significantly moderates relationships between some dimensions and attitudes, suggesting that OPRs have varying effects on attitudes for

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics and Correlations for OPRs Antecedents.

Relationships	k	N	r^-	r (range)	E.S.	95% CI		Homogeneity	
						Low	High	Q-value	I^2
Trust									
Involvement to trust#	7	2263	.42	[.38, .47]	.50	.44	.56	16.21	62.98%
Engagement to trust	10	3338	.48	[.24, .83]	.60	.42	.74	531.84 * **	98.31%
Authenticity to trust	9	4074	.65	[.55, .76]	.75	.71	.78	56.93 * *	85.95%
Transparency to trust	9	3789	.75	[.45, .83]	.85	.81	.88	121.83 * **	93.43%
Interactivity to trust	10	1959	.41	[.05, .77]	.52	.27	.70	424.09 * **	97.88%
Symmetrical to trust#	14	5495	.54	[.03, .75]	.57	.40	.75	527.55 * **	97.53%
Two-way to trust#	7	2274	.42	[.29, .63]	.47	.31	.64	43.42 * *	86.18%
Mediated to trust#	6	1764	.30	[.12, .56]	.35	.14	.57	64.54 * **	92.25%
Interpersonal to trust#	6	1764	.45	[.34, .63]	.55	.42	.68	42.07 * *	88.11%
Satisfaction									
Involvement to satisfaction#	7	2263	.41	[.35, .52]	.48	.37	.58	216.40 * **	97.23%
Engagement to satisfaction	10	3338	.47	[.16, .85]	.62	.36	.79	994.35 * **	99.10%
Authenticity to satisfaction	9	3672	.65	[.53, .77]	.72	.66	.76	98.57 * **	91.88%
Transparency to satisfaction	7	2965	.74	[.45, .82]	.86	.79	.90	179.43 * **	96.66%
Interactivity to satisfaction	7	1388	.48	[.07, .74]	.62	.27	.83	411.65 * **	98.54%
Symmetrical to satisfaction#	13	5103	.56	[.31, .74]	.62	.51	.73	317.96 * **	96.23%
Two-way to satisfaction#	5	1884	.39	[.21, .54]	.45	.33	.57	13.37	70.09%
Mediated to satisfaction#	5	1464	.21	[.06, .38]	.24	.03	.44	38.83 * *	89.70%
Interpersonal to satisfaction#	5	1884	.40	[.26, .48]	.49	.31	.66	25.54 *	84.34%
Commitment									
Involvement to commitment#	7	2263	.42	[.32, .52]	.48	.36	.59	217.84 * **	97.25%
Engagement to commitment	9	3006	.45	[.07, .75]	.56	.37	.71	429.75 * **	98.14%
Authenticity to commitment	7	2944	.58	[.41, .76]	.67	.57	.75	128.30 * **	95.32%
Transparency to commitment	7	2965	.72	[.45, .82]	.86	.75	.87	149.39 * **	95.98%
Interactivity to commitment	8	1463	.46	[.18, .75]	.58	.31	.76	327.37 * **	97.86%
Symmetrical to commitment#	12	5105	.54	[.30, .69]	.61	.52	.71	214.80 * **	94.88%
Two-way to commitment#	5	1464	.36	[.18, .52]	.44	.27	.61	25.45 *	84.28%
Mediated to commitment#	5	1464	.25	[.09, .38]	.29	.12	.46	26.42 *	84.86%
Interpersonal to commitment#	5	1464	.38	[.30, .45]	.47	.39	.56	6.34	36.88%
Control Mutuality									
Involvement to CM#	7	2263	.39	[.31, .50]	.40	.21	.59	201.40 * **	97.02%
Engagement to CM	4	918	.45	[.27, .79]	.58	.12	.84	270.59 * **	98.89%
Authenticity to CM	7	3346	.58	[.40, .73]	.67	.58	.75	123.79 * **	95.15%
Transparency to CM	7	2965	.72	[.34, .84]	.83	.74	.89	249.21 * **	97.59%
Interactivity to CM	7	1222	.44	[.04, .74]	.57	.29	.76	248.95 * **	97.59%
Symmetrical to CM#	14	5495	.51	[.03, .74]	.55	.41	.70	434.28 * **	97.01%
Two-way to CM#	7	1854	.40	[.19, .58]	.44	.24	.64	44.68 * *	86.57%
Mediated to CM#	6	2184	.25	[.04, .48]	.29	.03	.55	74.13 * **	93.26%
Interpersonal to CM#	6	1764	.41	[.19, .54]	.50	.29	.71	58.86 * **	91.51%

Note. k = number of samples; N = Aggregate sample size; r^- = Observed average effect size; ES = estimated effect size after correcting for measurement error; # Indicates using Robust Variance Estimation with small sample size correction; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

different types of organizations. Lastly, we found that the crisis research topic and channel do not moderate any of the included associations.

5. Discussion

In Broom et al.'s (1997) three-stage model, OPRs are outcomes of, as well as causes for, changes of antecedents to relationships and consequences of relationships. Our research supported this model with integrated empirical evidence in the overall strength of these antecedents and consequences and offered suggestions on which antecedents and consequences should be prioritized with a direct comparison of their association strengths. We also found several important factors that moderate the magnitude of these associations, which enriches the three-stage OPRs model and our understanding of OPRs. Below we further unpack our findings.

5.1. Antecedents and relational dimensions of OPRs

Our first research question investigated empirical relationships among antecedents (i.e., engagement, symmetrical communication, two-way communication, interpersonal communication, mediated communication, interactivity, authenticity, transparency, and involvement) and the four dimensions of OPRs: control mutuality, trust, satisfaction, and commitment (Broom et al., 1997; Chen, 2017; Hon &

Grunig, 1999; Huang, 2001b; Men, 2015; Men & Jiang, 2016; Men & Tsai, 2015; Tong, 2021). Generally, we found strong correlations between the four dimensions and these nine antecedents, resolving discrepancies in past research that had mixed effect sizes (e.g., Chen, 2017; Dong & Ji, 2018; Jo & Kim, 2003; Kujur & Singh, 2019; Men & Tsai, 2014, 2016; Tsai & Men, 2018; Vafeiadis, 2021).

Two closely related antecedents, perceived authenticity and transparency, were the strongest antecedents of OPRs. As we previously observed, researchers have found that authenticity and transparency have strong correlations with OPRs across a variety of topics, but the strength of the effects of authenticity on OPRs has varied across different topics and organization types (e.g., Dong & Ji, 2018; Kelleher et al., 2019; Lee et al., 2021; Men, 2015; Men & Jiang, 2016; Men & Tsai, 2014, 2016; Thelen, 2021). Our findings demonstrate that authenticity and transparency are imperative for developing and maintaining strong OPRs in any context. Much of the recent public relations research linking authenticity and OPRs is in the corporate social advocacy context (e.g., Lim & Young, 2021; Song & Choi, 2023), while this is also the case for transparency in the internal communication context (e.g., Kelleher et al., 2019; Kim & Lee, 2021; Men, 2015). Our findings indicate that authenticity and transparency should be central theoretical constructs in research on OPRs and likely in other public relations contexts as well.

In contrast, the mediated communication strategy exerted the least influence on relational dimensions across topics and contexts. This may

Table 2
Descriptive Statistics and Correlations for OPRs Consequences.

Relationships	k	N	r^-	r (range)	E.S.	95% CI		Homogeneity	
						Low	High	Q-value	I^2
Trust									
Trust to attitudes#	13	4312	.60	[.25, .85]	.63	.47	.79	914.15 ***	98.69%
Trust to advocacy	5	2180	.61	[.45, .72]	.71	.60	.79	73.07 ***	94.53%
Trust to positive word of mouth	7	3296	.55	[.30, .87]	.69	.48	.83	510.11 ***	98.82%
Trust to reputation#	9	2634	.60	[.38, .82]	.63	.49	.78	341.75 ***	97.66%
Trust to information seeking	7	3809	.25	[-.13, .43]	.30	.11	.48	241.50 ***	97.52%
Trust to purchase intention#	10	2717	.39	[.30, .56]	.46	.38	.54	57.60 **	84.38%
Satisfaction									
Satisfaction to attitudes#	13	4373	.65	[.43, .89]	.74	.58	.89	605.76 ***	98.02%
Satisfaction to advocacy	5	2180	.67	[.46, .82]	.76	.61	.85	169.32 ***	97.64%
Satisfaction to positive word of mouth	7	2585	.59	[.22, .90]	.72	.54	.84	366.43 ***	98.36%
Satisfaction to reputation#	11	3191	.57	[.22, .84]	.57	.40	.75	706.64 ***	98.59%
Satisfaction to information seeking	4	2423	.33	[.26, .39]	.39	.30	.47	18.09 *	83.42%
Satisfaction to purchase intention#	10	2717	.39	[.24, .63]	.46	.34	.58	141.14 ***	93.62%
Commitment									
Commitment to attitudes#	13	3922	.63	[.19, .85]	.67	.50	.85	1249.88 ***	99.04%
Commitment to advocacy	4	1848	.57	[.34, .80]	.68	.36	.86	273.07 ***	98.90%
Commitment to positive word of mouth	5	1673	.57	[.32, .88]	.70	.43	.85	271.61 ***	98.53%
Commitment to reputation#	9	2634	.58	[.29, .79]	.60	.43	.77	370.10 ***	97.57%
Commitment to information seeking	4	2423	.35	[.32, .40]	.43	.36	.49	11.47	73.85%
Commitment to purchase intention#	9	2155	.39	[.22, .62]	.46	.35	.58	105.15 ***	92.39%
Control Mutuality									
CM to attitudes#	13	3922	.58	[.30, .81]	.66	.54	.79	408.00 ***	97.06%
CM to advocacy	4	1848	.50	[.32, .70]	.58	.37	.74	108.82 ***	97.24%
CM to positive word of mouth	5	1673	.55	[.27, .83]	.67	.41	.82	217.74 ***	98.16%
CM to reputation#	5	1943	.70	[.68, .73]	.80	.72	.88	68.47 ***	94.16%
CM to information seeking	5	2627	.40	[.36, .45]	.50	.47	.54	4.73	15.43%
CM to purchase intention#	9	2155	.38	[.28, .50]	.46	.37	.56	61.92 ***	87.08%

Note. k = number of samples; N = Aggregate sample size; r^- = Observed average effect size; ES = estimated effect size after correcting for measurement error; # Indicates using Robust Variance Estimation with small sample size correction; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

Table 3
Moderation Analysis for OPRs Antecedents for Categorical Moderators (Only Showing Significant Results).

Pairwise relationships	χ^2	E.S. (number of samples)			
		Country	U.S.	China	
Engagemen to trust	4.81 *		.46 (5)	.77 (4)	
Engagement to satisfaction	5.29 *		.42 (5)	.81 (4)	
Engagement to commitment	8.11 **		.42 (4)	.74 (4)	
		Sampling method	Nonrepresentative	Representative	
Symmetrical to commitment	7.68 *		.59 (8)	.73 (4)	
		Organization type	For-profit organizations	Governments (political organizations)	Non-profit organization (NPOs)
Symmetrical to trust	12.01 **		.80 (3)	.60 (5)	.65 (5)
Symmetrical to satisfaction	102.12 ***		.79 (3)	.52 (5)	.71 (4)
Symmetrical to commitment	76.54 ***		.77 (2)	.50 (5)	.73 (4)
Symmetrical to CM	8.72 *		.75 (3)	.56 (6)	.63 (5)
		EORs	Employee	Non-employee	
Symmetrical to satisfaction	7.15 **		.75 (6)	.57 (7)	-
Symmetrical to commitment	12.07 **		.74 (5)	.56 (7)	
Authenticity to satisfaction	6.09 *		.77 (4)	.67 (5)	
Authenticity to commitment	8.48 **		.74 (4)	.57 (3)	
Authenticity to CM	4.47 *		.73 (4)	.58 (3)	

Note. E.S. = estimated effect size. † $p < .10$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

Table 4
Moderation Analysis for Consequences of OPRs for Categorical Moderators (Only Showing Significant Results).

Pairwise relationships	χ^2	E.S. (number of samples)			
		Sampling method	Nonrepresentative	Representative	
Commitment to reputation	6.71 *		.83 (4)	.58 (5)	
		Organization type	For-profit organizations	Governments (political organizations)	Non-profit organization (NPOs)
Trust to attitudes	5.03†		.64 (5)	.86 (5)	.67 (3)
Commitment to attitudes	8.43 *		.63 (5)	.90 (5)	.72 (3)

Note. E.S. = estimated effect size. † $p < .10$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

be due to the changing media landscape where many organizations and publics primarily communicate via mediated modes, thereby making this vehicle for communication the default rather than a unique vehicle to cultivate OPRs. Furthermore, the time span of studies incorporating this strategy is quite substantial, indicating that the interpreted mediated communication may also vary with communication technology development (Huang, 2001b; Ni et al., 2015; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011a, 2011b). Future research could test this possibility by differentiating various types of mediated communication for their potential influence on OPRs and other important public relations outcomes (Xu, 2020). However, these arguments should be interpreted cautiously, as the number of associations incorporating these strategies is not abundant, with only five to six associations for each dimension of OPRs.

Other relationship maintenance strategies, along with engagement and interactivity, also strongly influence OPRs, though less than authenticity and transparency. These findings showcase why OPRs have been a dominant force in public relations theorizing and practice (Dozier et al., 2013; Huang, 2001b; Ki et al., 2019; PRSA, 2012). Relationships are indeed the cornerstone of public relations and must be strategically maintained over time. Our findings further confirm that public relations scholars have successfully identified an arsenal of antecedents that predict positive OPRs. The following section discusses the consequences of OPRs.

5.2. Relational dimensions and consequences of OPRs

Research question two examined the four dimensions of OPRs (i.e., control mutuality, trust, satisfaction, and commitment) and the consequences identified in the prior literature (i.e., organizational reputation, publics' attitudes, publics' purchase intentions, publics' positive word-of-mouth communication, publics' advocacy, and publics' information seeking) (e.g., Ki & Hon, 2007b; Men & Tsai, 2014; Men, 2015; Ma, 2018; Ni et al., 2019; Park & Reber, 2011).

We found that OPRs have the strongest impacts on attitudes and advocacy, around 0.70 in effect size across all topics and contexts. OPRs generally have the least influence on information seeking, possibly because information seeking requires a cognitive processing burden and related literacies (Ou & Ho, 2022; Wang et al., 2021). These findings point to where positive OPRs can have strong impacts (e.g., publics' attitudes about an organization) and where factors other than OPRs must be considered in order to support publics' needs (e.g., information acquisition), lending support for public relations theories that focus on publics' communicative behaviors such as the situational theory of problem solving (STOPS, Chon et al., 2023; Kim & Grunig, 2011).

A line of research has integrated OPRs and STOPS to predict publics' communicative actions during public health crises (Chon & Park, 2021; Chon et al., 2023; Kim & Grunig, 2011). Our findings indicate OPRs as a strong theoretical framework to continue integrating with other public relations theories, consistent with the finding of a recent content analysis that examined articles in *Public Relations Review* and the *Journal of Public Relations Research* from 2010 to 2020 (Zhou et al., 2023). Another example is that, in the crisis context, scholars have begun to investigate how OPRs intersect with the fully functioning society theory to understand community disaster resilience (Atwell Seate et al., 2022).

Furthermore, our findings point to a fruitful area of future research: identifying new consequences of OPRs. As we noted above, scholars have just begun to identify additional consequences, such as community resilience (Atwell Seate et al., 2022; Kim et al., 2023), and additional research is needed to better understand other potential consequences of OPRs, including potential negative consequences.

5.3. Moderators

Our last two research questions examined moderators in relationships among OPRs, their antecedents, and consequences. We found that sampling method, country, employee topic, and organization types are

significant moderators, while channel and crisis topic are not. Based on our Q Test results and I² Indices for these antecedents and outcomes presented in Tables 1 and 2, we conclude that most associations included in this meta-analysis have heterogeneity among studies, thus justifying the need to conduct moderation analyses. However, several associations appear to be homogeneous, such as involvement to trust, two-way communication to satisfaction, and commitment and control mutuality to information seeking associations. This suggests that variability among these studies was likely due to sampling error instead of characteristics that vary among the studies. We further discuss the interpretations and implications of our moderation analysis below.

5.3.1. Sampling method

Representative samples tend to produce a significantly stronger relationship between symmetrical communication and commitment than nonrepresentative samples. However, representative samples tend to produce a significantly weaker correlation than nonrepresentative samples in the relationship between commitment and reputation. Therefore, public relations scholars should be cautious when using nonrepresentative samples and making recommendations for practice (Ismagilova et al., 2020; Ou & Ho, 2022; Wang et al., 2021). Ideally, scholars should secure funding to conduct research with representative samples of the target publics or partner with organizations to conduct research. Ma and Zhan (2016) concluded that college students, as a group, are more homogenous in some respects, such as educational level, age, and cognitive ability, than non-student samples. Similarly, non-representative samples tend to be self-selective and therefore may be more homogenous in some respects than the representative samples. This relative homogeneity may amplify or downplay the strengths of some conceptual links that scholars are interested in, compared to the strengths of those links in representative samples.

5.3.2. Country

The engagement-OPRs associations were consistently stronger in China than in the U.S. within the included studies (e.g., Chen, 2017; Dong & Ji, 2018; Men & Muralidharan, 2017; Tsai & Men, 2018), similar to findings from another meta-analysis that compared this association between Western and Eastern Asia cultures (Zhan & Zhao, 2023). These effect size differences could be related to the underlying cultural differences between the two countries. First, as a widely applied cultural dimension theory, the individualism-collectivism (IC) framework distinguishes between societies based on their social behavior norms (Chu et al., 2020; Hofstede et al., 2005; Huang et al., 2023; Tang et al., 2015). Specifically, societies leaning towards individualism encourage open expression of personal feelings and opinions, fostering loose ties among individuals. Collectivist societies emphasize strong, cohesive interpersonal connections, with harmony-seeking, conflict-avoidance, and an authority-directed orientation often taking precedence (Hofstede et al., 2005). In this context, engagement as a mechanism of fostering connection, interaction, participation, and involvement is more culturally aligned in collectivist societies. Therefore, it is possible that engagement would play a larger role in determining OPRs in collectivist cultures than in individualistic ones, as previous studies suggested that OPRs in China and the U.S. were shaped by the individualistic-collectivistic cultural differences (Huang et al., 2023; Men & Muralidharan, 2017; Ngai & Singh, 2018).

However, the IC framework has been critiqued for its conceptual issues and its purported universal applicability (Earley & Gibson, 1998; Huang et al., 2018; McSweeney, 2002). As such, the concepts of relational and group collectivism have emerged as more refined tools for cross-cultural analysis (Brewer & Chen, 2007). Relational collectivism represents societies where self-identity is seen as part of a network of reciprocal relationships where relationship maintenance is valued over personal interests, while group collectivism views the self as an interchangeable component of a larger social entity where group interests are valued over personal interests (Brewer & Chen, 2007). China, in

particular, is considered a strongly relationally collectivist society, emphasizing positive, long-term relationships (Brewer & Chen, 2007; Huang et al., 2018; Leung et al., 2014). These cultural values of maintaining harmonious and reciprocally beneficial relationships potentially magnify the influence of engagement on OPRs. As such, relational collectivism may offer another explanation for the stronger association between engagement and OPRs observed in China compared to the U.S. (Huang et al., 2018; 2023).

5.3.3. Engagement and involvement

As discussed previously, engagement and involvement were used interchangeably in some studies (Lewis et al., 2001; Men & Tsai, 2015), but they have distinctive conceptualization and operationalization in another line of research (Bortree, 2011; Browning et al., 2020; Harrison, 2018). We found that engagement and involvement are consistently different, supporting the notion that these two concepts are inherently unique and should be treated differently. Engagement has a stronger influence on OPRs than involvement across all studied topics and contexts. This difference may be caused by the fact that engagement emphasizes all interactions and connections publics have with an organization, while involvement mostly focuses on the relevance of the organization with publics' inherent needs, values, and interests (Browning et al., 2020; Johnston & Taylor, 2018; Zaichkowsky, 1985).

This finding suggests that future research should conceptually and operationally distinguish engagement and involvement in study designs. Moreover, for organizations that aim to build or sustain strong relationships with key publics, public relations approaches that center engagement (e.g., a psychological and behavioral construct ranging from passive message consumption to active two-way conversation, participation, and recommendation) rather than involvement (e.g., a cognitive construct reflecting the degree of perceived relevance of an object derived from one's inherent needs, values, and interests) appear to be more fruitful in sustaining strong OPRs (Browning et al., 2020; Harrison, 2018; Harrison et al., 2017; Men & Tsai, 2014; Tsai & Men, 2017; Zaichkowsky, 1985).

5.3.4. Crisis topic

While crisis communication dominates recent public relations scholarship (Page & Capizzo, 2021), it has been underexplored in the OPRs literature compared to other topics (e.g., internal communication). Five crisis studies were included in the meta-analysis with information seeking as the consequence of OPRs, but no significant moderation was found. There were not enough effect sizes for other crisis antecedents and consequences to conclude whether OPRs would have different relationships with these antecedents and consequences in and out of the crisis context. More examination on how OPRs influence and are impacted by crisis-specific antecedents and consequences (e.g., crisis types and timing, crisis response strategies, prior and post-crisis reputation, and blame, see Cheng et al., 2022 for a review) and other non-crisis-specific variables (e.g., interactivity, transparency, attitudes, and positive word-of-mouth communication) in the crisis context is suggested.

5.3.5. Employee topic

Contrary to the crisis topic, EORs research has received wide scholarly attention in the literature, and a majority of these studies have examined what antecedents can be applied to build strong EORs (e.g., Kelleher et al., 2019; Lee et al., 2021; Men, 2015; Men & Jiang, 2016; Thelen, 2021). By directly comparing EORs with other contexts, our findings add to the literature by providing integrated evidence on how relationships are uniquely nurtured in different contexts. Specifically, symmetrical communication and authenticity have stronger effects on satisfaction and commitment in the internal communication context. Authenticity also has a stronger effect on control mutuality in the internal communication context compared to other contexts.

The comparison of OPRs in the internal communication context with

other contexts opens up a new avenue for understanding how contexts shape OPRs and the strategies effective in building and maintaining relationships with distinct publics. We echo recent critiques of the absence of context in much OPRs research that recruits participants who interact, engage, or volunteer with any organization, rather than true publics (Sommerfeldt & Heath, 2023; Sommerfeldt & Iannacone, 2023).

5.3.6. Organization type

We found that the relationships between symmetrical communication and all dimensions of OPRs are weaker in studies examining political organizations than in studies examining for-profit organizations and combined organizations, reconciling the inconsistent findings we observed in the maintenance strategies section in the literature review (Huang, 2001b; Kim, 2018; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee et al., 2022). We also found that the relationships between trust and commitment, and attitudes were stronger for political organizations and non-profit organizations than for-profit organizations, indicating that organization type may be one of the underlying factors that leads to previous inconsistent findings (Kang & Yang, 2010; Ki & Hon, 2007b; Kim & Gower, 2021; Ma, 2018; Seltzer et al., 2013).

These findings support recent arguments that OPRs should vary based on the organizational context instead of a common desired type of relationship (Coombs & Holladay, 2015; Sommerfeldt & Heath, 2023). Investigating OPRs in a specific organizational context is imperative to provide insights for practitioners seeking effective strategies tailored to their organizational needs, as some scholars have begun to pursue (Abitbol & Sternadori, 2019; Atwell Seate et al., 2022; Kim et al., 2023). Furthermore, our findings highlight the need for future research to delve deeper into the unique dynamics of OPRs across different organizational contexts. Research could compare the same set of antecedents and consequences in at least two organizational contexts in a single study, similar to what cross-cultural studies do (Huang et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2020; Men & Muralidharan, 2017).

5.3.7. Channel

We found that channel does not moderate any of the studied associations, similar to the finding that there is no significant difference between using traditional media and social media on persuasiveness from a meta-analysis examining social media and traditional media use in crisis communication (Xu, 2020). Across different channels, the relationships between OPRs and their relational antecedents and outcomes do not vary systematically. Social media allow organizations to release information and respond to their publics in a timely manner. However, this advantage of social media does not affect the function of OPRs. One explanation is that some organizations, in general, have not fully or effectively taken advantage of the timeliness and interactivity of social media to communicate with their publics. An alternative explanation is that real-time interaction may not be very important for the functions of OPRs, since it takes a long time to establish quality OPRs. Real-time interaction is more important for short-term or urgent situations, such as in a crisis (Utz et al., 2013) when publics have high expectations for timely and interactive communication. We suggest that the channel should not be the focus of future research.

5.3.8. Dimensions of OPRs

Lastly, we find inconsistent findings in the moderation analysis for the four dimensions, although OPRs generally have similar effect sizes with their antecedents and outcomes. This finding implies that these four dimensions (i.e., trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality) are inherently different. Taking OPRs as one latent variable, as the common approach in recent years, may leave out some important information, such as the moderating effects of other variables on certain dimensions (e.g., Dong & Ji, 2018; Kim & Gower, 2021; Men, 2015). However, this finding may be attributed to the small number of effect sizes in this study. Future studies can specifically test if moderators differ for different dimensions of OPRs.

5.4. Practical implications

This study offers multiple practical implications. First, for organizations, we found that the most effective strategies to strengthen OPRs are authenticity and transparency across external and internal contexts, countries, and organization types. Thus, public relations practitioners should integrate authenticity and transparency into their strategies and tactics whenever possible to cultivate and maintain long-term positive OPRs. Importantly, authenticity and transparency transcend cultures and countries, making them ideal for public relations efforts in diverse contexts.

Second, findings indicate that, for organizations from China or international organizations operating in China, engagement does not work as effectively as it does in the U.S. for cultivating quality OPRs. Thus, other strategies should be prioritized over engagement for cultivating strong OPRs with publics in China. In the U.S., engagement is still one of the most fruitful avenues for cultivating quality OPRs.

Third, we found that for different types of organizations, the impact of symmetrical communication on OPRs varies. The findings indicate that for-profit organizations should place more emphasis on symmetrical communication to cultivate OPRs compared to political organizations. Conversely, the influence of OPRs on attitudes in political organizations is stronger compared to for-profit organizations and non-profit organizations. These findings highlight the unique importance of building quality OPRs for political organizations to sustain publics' favorable attitudes. Finally, the effects of symmetrical communication and authenticity on OPRs show a stronger enhancement for employees compared to non-employees. Thus, organizations should particularly value symmetrical communication and authenticity for employees in order to cultivate positive internal OPRs.

5.5. Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, the number of included studies is not large for most investigated associations since repetitive works do not receive the same recognition as innovative ones. However, our sample size is not unusual for a meta-analysis in social science research (Hunter & Schmidt, 2004; Ma & Zhan, 2016; Xu, 2020). Another reason for the relatively modest sample size is that not all studies provided enough statistics for analyzing effect sizes. Therefore, we call for researchers to report statistical results in more standardized ways (e.g., a correlation matrix for all variables included in the study). Shared data and analytics procedures would also benefit the research community, which could be submitted to journals as supplementary materials.

Second, we only compared studies conducted in the U.S. to those conducted in China for the moderator analysis of the country. This is because we only have enough studies to conduct the moderator analysis on these two countries since most existing studies examined OPRs in the U.S. and China, with only a few exceptions, such as Korea, India, and Yemeni. Consequently, the results of the moderator analysis of the country cannot be generalized to Eastern versus Western cultures.

5.6. Suggestions for future research

This research focused on the antecedents and outcomes that have been dominantly examined in published research. The findings here by no means indicate these are the most influential antecedents or most salient outcomes of OPRs. There are many other concepts that have been studied in the literature. Future research should investigate other theoretically promising concepts, such as organizational resilience (Kim, 2020), community resilience (Kim et al., 2023; Liu & Ni, 2021), and emotions (Zhan & Zhao, 2021), to enrich the OPRs theoretical framework.

We also recommend extending our understanding of the potential negative outcomes of ineffective OPRs. The current research examines

word-of-mouth communication (Browning et al., 2020; Chen et al., 2021) and purchase intentions (e.g., Browning et al., 2020; Dhanesh & Duthler, 2019; Kim & Gower, 2021), which could be negatively valenced if strong OPRs do not exist. Echoing Waymer and Heath's (2021) criticism that we often focus on the positive effects of public relations, and not potential negative effects, we call on scholars to consider the potential negative outcomes of OPRs.

As previously mentioned, we echo calls for cross-contextual and cross-organizational studies to directly compare how OPRs are nurtured and have consequences in varying contexts and types of organizations (Coombs & Holladay, 2015; Sommerfeldt & Heath, 2023; Yang & Grunig, 2005). Only two included studies in this meta-analysis conducted such comparative research (i.e., OPRs in different organizations) (Abitbol & Sternadori, 2019; Yang & Grunig, 2005), warranting more scholarly examination. Additionally, our understanding of OPRs in countries/cultures, besides the U.S. and China, is very limited. As shown by the significant differences across cultures in this study, more explorations of OPRs in diverse countries and cultural regions are warranted, as also mentioned in other OPRs reviews (Huang & Zhang, 2013; Ki & Shin, 2015; Zhan & Zhao, 2023).

We also recommend that scholars carefully consider whether their study designs allow for testing OPRs, depending upon how publics are conceptualized. As Sommerfeldt and Iannacone (2023) questioned: "What factors make these populations a public besides the fact that they were included in a sample?" (p. 33). In this study, we did not contest authors' stances on whether their samples were indeed publics of the organizations they studied. However, this is important for future scholars to consider as we further refine OPRs theory. Also, of critical importance for future research is to test OPRs with specific, discrete publics, potentially in combination with STOPS. Such research should investigate one or more publics' relationships with a specific problem and a specific organization (Sommerfeldt & Heath, 2023).

We further recommend the use of longitudinal methods to examine OPRs. None of the included research in this meta-analysis used a longitudinal design to examine the causal directions among antecedents and consequences, the long-term effects of these antecedents on OPRs, or the long-term effects of OPRs on consequences, similar to what previous OPRs reviews mentioned (Huang & Zhang, 2015; Zhan & Zhao, 2023).

Lastly, we suggest that future research replicate our procedures as recommended by meta-analysis experts. These experts have noted that using standardized regression coefficients in a meta-analysis, instead of correlation coefficients, is a controversial issue (Fernández-Castilla et al., 2019; Nieminen, 2022; Peterson & Brown, 2005). We requested correlation coefficients from the authors to ensure accuracy since standardized regression coefficients come from models that include different sets of covariates and variables apart from the independent and dependent variables of interest (Fernández-Castilla et al., 2019; Peterson & Brown, 2005). In our study, the estimated effects sizes of engagement to associations are consistently higher than another, smaller-scale OPRs meta-analysis that used standardized regression coefficients (Zhan & Zhao, 2023).

6. Conclusion

Guided by Broom et al.'s (1997) three-stage model of OPRs, this research confirms strong relationships among OPRs and their dominant antecedents and consequences in the extant research, which enriches the three-stage model with integrated empirical evidence. We also identify sampling method, country, employee topic, and organization type as significant moderators for certain relationships, which reconcile incongruous previous findings and set an agenda for future research. We further identified areas for growth in the OPRs scholarship, including longitudinal studies, studies with more diverse global publics, studies with cross-contextual and cross-organizational designs, attention to how publics are conceptualized, and studies that consider under what

conditions positive relationships may not be the primary concern. Overall, we find that OPRs is a mature and well-supported theory that continues integrating with other public relations theories and is well-aligned with the relational core of many public relations practices.

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Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare no competing interests.

Data Availability

The authors do not have permission to share data.

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